

these touchpoints. These could be either paid or organic to improve sales in traditional channels or risk reducing conversions.”

Satya Raghavan, Director-Marketing Partners at Google India, says its content strategy is about media, tech and creative coming together. He says video is the gateway to the internet. “A new user first thinks about video and then does other things.” And the gateway to video is YouTube. Gupta says YouTube is about democratising content creation at scale: “Today, you have them coming from remote corners and managing to find

mium subscribers from 50 million in September 2021 and there is a lot of headroom to grow in India as well.”

A large universe of advertisers can be tapped with YouTube and its product suite. According to Abhishek Maity, Co-founder of Adbuffs, a digital-first agency, one can get started on Google Search for as little as ₹100 a day. With a roster of clients ranging from enterprises to MSMEs to small entrepreneurs selling imitation jewellery, beauty cosmetics, and much else, he picks out detailed targeting as a huge advantage. “One can narrow the audience to a particular pin

and will remain at the premium position, making growth in volumes a challenge. After all, over 90 per cent of the market in India has phones priced at below ₹30,000, where iOS has almost no play,” he says.

Another advantage, as Tarun Pathak, Research Director-Devices and Ecosystems at Counterpoint Research, puts it, is that Android is an open-source OS that allows for a high level of customisation. “In India, 76 per cent of consumers spend under \$250 on a smartphone, and here, Android is dominant, compared to Apple, which targets the over-\$400 seg-



**“AS CLOUD COMPUTING BECAME A MAINSTREAM TECHNOLOGY, WE SAW AN OPPORTUNITY TO OFFER THIS TO OUR POTENTIAL CUSTOMERS”**

**BIKRAM SINGH BEDI**  
MANAGING DIRECTOR,  
GOOGLE CLOUD INDIA



**“GLOBALLY, WE ARE AT 80 MILLION MUSIC AND PREMIUM SUBSCRIBERS... AND THERE IS A LOT OF HEADROOM TO GROW IN INDIA AS WELL”**

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DIRECTOR, MARKETING PARTNERS,  
GOOGLE INDIA

an audience. Our ad products have made this more sustainable.”

The kind of users coming on to YouTube is interesting. Raghavan picks out the small film industries in Bihar, coastal Karnataka and in the Dakhani language. “Today, YouTube can generate data for one film trailer and based on the feedback, producers can decide the release strategy in terms of number of prints and where to put them out,” he says. Of course, YouTube channels have proliferated across entertainment, personal finance, cooking, education and pretty much everything you can think of. Raghavan is also optimistic about YouTube Premium, a paid platform in price-sensitive India. “Globally, we are at 80 million music and pre-

code using Google Maps. More importantly, there is scope for course correction,” says Maity.

**O**NE BIG AREA of success for Google has been its Android mobile operating system (OS), which has a 95 per cent share of the smartphone market. A large number of affordable smartphone models on the platform has helped. Navkendar Singh, Associate Vice President of IDC India, goes back to the period starting 2013-14 when Android OS was launched by Indian brands such as Micromax and Lava followed by Samsung and, later, the very aggressive Chinese vendors. “iOS (Apple’s mobile OS) has been

ment.” The next frontier is the 200 million user base that is still on feature phones. To target this user base, Google partnered with Reliance Jio to launch JioPhone Next, an entry-level smartphone in 2021. “However, its pricing missed the mark and is still out of reach of feature phone users,” says IDC’s Singh. Google’s Gupta speaks of how his teams are “reimagining the experience driven by voice, and we are working with Jio and Airtel to bring more options for users to make that transition”.

The premium smartphone (upwards of ₹50,000) market is being targeted, too, with the Pixel 7 series, but making headway there won’t be easy. “Although the market is growing, it is almost a duopoly between